

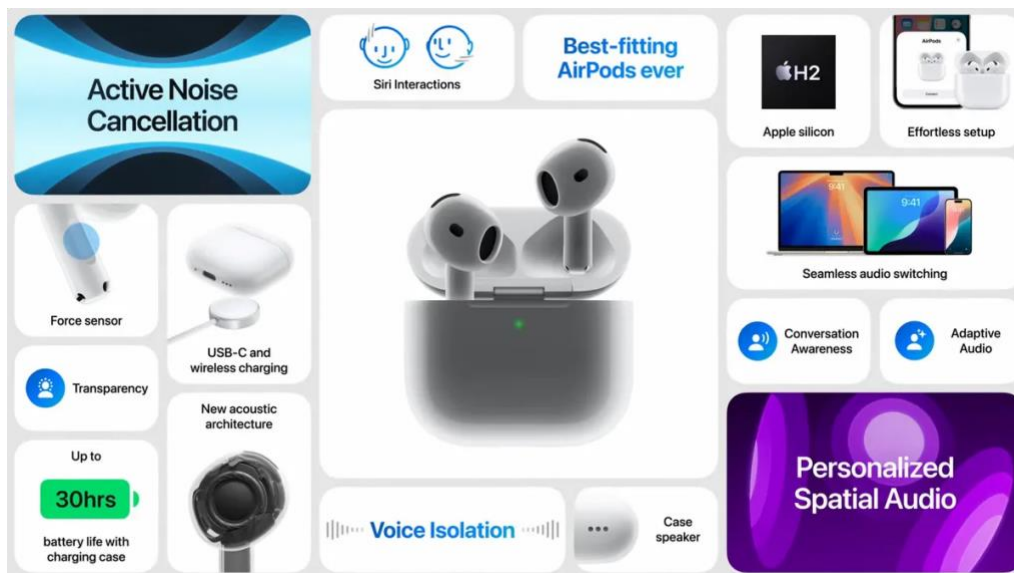
AirPods 4 Review: A Pleasant Surprise

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The new Apple AirPods 4 were unveiled in Apple's 'Glowtime' event this past September have generated lots of hype and confusion around them. I would like to cut through the confusion to give a worthwhile review for prospective buyers.

The AirPods 4 were released in two very similar but distinct models, the AirPods 4 with active noise cancellation (ANC) and the version without ANC. These models provide consumers with a choice between a more premium feature set or a more budget-friendly option while still having the same foundation. The ANC model is priced at \$179, while the non-ANC model costs \$129. Apple kept the price of the ANC model the same as the launch price of the AirPods 3, which is impressive given the recent price hikes to many other wireless earbuds like the Galaxy Buds3 which had a price increase of thirty dollars over its predecessor. Though the price difference on the AirPods primarily reflects the inclusion of ANC, there are other subtle differences between the two models that prospective buyers should consider.

For instance, the model with ANC comes equipped with a Qi-capable charging case, allowing for wireless charging and compatibility with Apple Watch chargers, making it highly convenient for users within the Apple ecosystem. On the other hand, the non-ANC model features a regular charging case without Qi wireless charging capabilities, requiring users to depend on the USB-C cable without the extra flexibility that wireless charging allows.



(Apple, 2024)

Both models are considered to be a side grade from the MagSafe charging case that was introduced as an optional upgrade for the AirPods 3. While MagSafe offered a more streamlined and efficient wireless charging solution, it still utilized Apple's proprietary Lightning cable for wired charging, rather than transitioning to the more universally adopted USB-C standard.

Perhaps the most significant internal upgrade in both AirPods 4 models is the transition from the H1 chip, which was found in the older AirPods 2 and 3, to the more advanced H2 chip. The H2 chip had previously only been available in the higher-end AirPods Pro 2, but now brings improved audio processing, connectivity, and overall performance to the AirPods 4. This chip upgrade allows for 'Voice isolation' and 'Personalized volume' both of which are major improvements for the AirPods 4 over previous models. Another improvement is the addition of an upgraded vent system for pressure equalization which further improves sound quality. (Apple, n.d.) Apple has touted the AirPods 4 as their 'best fitting AirPods ever' (Apple, n.d.-a), boasting improvements in ergonomics and fit that could appeal to a wide range of users. However, some consumers may still prefer the silicone ear tips of the AirPods Pro, which create a better sound barrier for noise cancellation and tend to fit more securely in the ear than the standard design of the regular AirPods.

One downside to using ANC on the AirPods 4 is the impact on the device's battery life. While the non-ANC version offers up to five hours of playback, enabling ANC on the premium model reduces this to four hours. (Apple, n.d.) Though this could be considered a minimal reduction for most users, it could be a consideration for users who prioritize battery life over the active noise cancellation.

In terms of usability enhancements, a notable improvement over the AirPods 3 is the addition of a speaker built into the case of both AirPods 4 models. This small but valuable feature is useful for locating the AirPods case using the Find My app, a particularly handy tool for users prone to misplacing their devices. Personally, I was surprised with the upgrades without a price hike especially considering the inflation from over the last few years that has made many other technology products increase their prices to keep their margins high. Overall, the AirPods 4 lineup brings several enhancements that improve upon the previous generation, while also giving many people more flexibility in choosing a model that best fits their preferences and budget.

Citations:

1. Apple. (n.d.-a). *AirPods 4*. <https://www.apple.com/airpods-4/>
2. Apple. (n.d.). *AirPods 4 - Technical Specifications*. <https://www.apple.com/airpods-4/specs/>
3. Apple. (2024, September 9). *Apple Event - September 9* [Video]. YouTube. https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=uarNiSl_uh4